

# Post-Driver-Assignment Clarity Redesign

DriveU assigns drivers early to guarantee availability for scheduled rides, but never tells users that. So when users see a dynamic ETA right after booking, they assume the driver is already on his way. The confusion that follows drives unnecessary cancellations. This case study documents how I identified that mismatch, validated it through research, and designed a focused solution to fix it.

| PRODUCT | SEGMENT               | CORE PROBLEM                        | SOLUTION                      | PRIMARY METRIC                    |
|---------|-----------------------|-------------------------------------|-------------------------------|-----------------------------------|
| DriveU  | Occasional Need Users | Post-assignment lifecycle confusion | Clarity Module (3 components) | Post-assignment cancellation rate |

## PHASE 1

### PRODUCT UNDERSTANDING & PROBLEM HYPOTHESIS

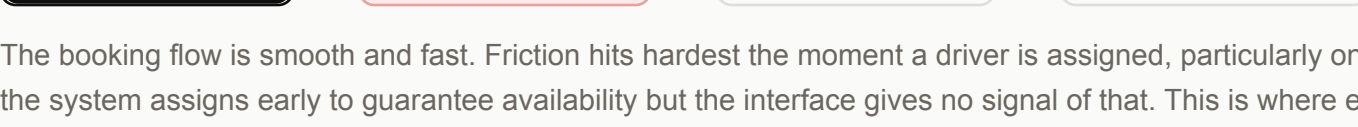
#### Mapping the core flow and finding where friction lives

Before forming any hypothesis, I mapped DriveU's full ride lifecycle, from app open to payment, to identify where the emotional high points and friction clusters were.

#### BUSINESS CONTEXT

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| <b>MISSION</b><br><b>Reliable, verified drivers on demand</b><br>DriveU exists to let car owners travel safely in their own vehicle, particularly in situations where driving themselves isn't an option. | <b>REVENUE MODEL</b><br><b>Commission + membership</b><br>The business earns a commission on every completed trip, supplemented by a membership programme. Trip completion is the revenue engine. | <b>BUSINESS GOAL</b><br><b>Maximise trip completion and retention</b><br>Every cancellation after driver assignment is a direct revenue loss. Repeat usage is what turns a platform into a habit. |
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#### CORE USER FLOW: WHERE DOES FRICTION APPEAR?



The booking flow is smooth and fast. Friction hits hardest the moment a driver is assigned, particularly on scheduled rides, where the system assigns early to guarantee availability but the interface gives no signal of that. This is where emotional volatility peaks.

#### FEATURE REVERSE ENGINEERING

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| <b>ON-DEMAND BOOKING</b><br><b>Solves urgency, drives conversion</b><br>The booking flow is lean and fast, designed to remove friction between intent and confirmation. It does this well. | <b>LIVE TRACKING</b><br><b>Builds trust through visibility</b><br>Seeing the driver on a map is reassuring. But visibility without context backfires when the driver hasn't started moving yet. | <b>GAP IDENTIFIED</b><br><b>Post-assignment lifecycle is underdeveloped</b><br>DriveU invests heavily in the booking experience. The period between driver assignment and ride execution is left largely unexplained. |
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#### USER SEGMENTATION: WHY I FOCUSED ON OCCASIONAL NEED USERS

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| <b>FOCUS SEGMENT</b><br><b>Occasional Need Users</b><br>Late nights, events, situations where driving isn't an option. Lowest cognitive bandwidth, highest emotional stakes. Most likely to cancel when confused. | <b>SECONDARY SEGMENT</b><br><b>Planned Long-Duration Users</b><br>Airport runs, intercity travel. Books well in advance. More patient, but still confused by scheduled ETA messaging. | <b>SECONDARY SEGMENT</b><br><b>Regular Repeat Users</b><br>Daily commuters who know the platform well. High familiarity means confusion-driven churn is much lower here. |
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## PHASE 1 HYPOTHESIS

**WHERE I LANDED**

**Occasional Need Users struggle to feel in control after a driver is assigned, and that loss of control is what drives them to cancel.**

The most emotionally fragile moment in the ride lifecycle isn't the booking. It's the waiting period immediately after assignment. That's where the research needed to go.

## PHASE 2

### USER RESEARCH, VALIDATION & PROBLEM PRIORITISATION

#### Validating the hypothesis through real user insight

I ran 3 in-depth interviews and collected 6 survey responses, using story-based questioning to surface what users actually experience, not just what they say they do. The core finding was a consistent mismatch between what the platform does and what users think it's doing.

#### WHAT THE RESEARCH REVEALED

|                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                         |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                           |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                     |
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| <b>INTERVIEW INSIGHT 1</b><br><b>The misleading ETA</b><br>A user booked a ride 2 hours ahead. The app showed "Driver 18 min away." He read that as the driver actively coming toward him, right now. He cancelled in a panic. He wasn't wrong to be confused; the UI gave him no other interpretation. | <b>INTERVIEW INSIGHT 2</b><br><b>Modification triggers cancellation</b><br>Users wanted to change small details like pickup point and time, but couldn't without cancelling. Digging deeper, most of these requests stemmed from confusion about driver status, not genuine plan changes. | <b>INTERVIEW INSIGHT 3</b><br><b>The penalty destroys trust</b><br>A ₹100 cancellation charge, levied even when the user cancelled out of confusion rather than intent, left users feeling punished by the platform. Several said they switched to Uber afterwards. |
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#### PAIN POINTS: RIDER VS DRIVER PERSPECTIVE

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| <b>Rider Pain Points</b> <ul style="list-style-type: none"><li>– Misreads the scheduled ETA as the driver actively en route right now. <b>CONFUSION</b></li><li>– No indication of what's happening between driver assignment and pickup. <b>ANXIETY</b></li><li>– Cancels unnecessarily because the waiting period feels unexplained. <b>CHURN</b></li><li>– Gets charged ₹100 for a confusion-driven cancel, not an intentional one. <b>TRUST DAMAGE</b></li><li>– Calls the driver prematurely because the app gives no reassurance. <b>FRICTION</b></li></ul> | <b>Driver Pain Points</b> <ul style="list-style-type: none"><li>– Gets calls from confused riders before the pickup window has even opened. <b>DISRUPTION</b></li><li>– Interruptions during non-active periods increase risk and reduce focus. <b>SAFETY</b></li><li>– Early cancellations waste an allocated slot, and idle time grows. <b>EFFICIENCY</b></li><li>– Late-night cancellations leave drivers stranded with no replacement trip in a low-supply period. <b>REVENUE</b></li></ul> |
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#### USER JOURNEY MAP: EMOTIONAL ARC

| STAGE           | USER ACTION                        | SYSTEM STATE                    | WHAT THE USER IS THINKING                                 | EMOTION    |
|-----------------|------------------------------------|---------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------|------------|
| Booking         | Enters details, confirms ride      | Processing request              | "Great, sorted."                                          | Confident  |
| Driver Assigned | Sees driver name and ETA appear    | Driver reserved for pickup time | "He's on his way"                                         | Relieved   |
| ETA Confusion   | Waits. Re-reads the 18-minute ETA. | Driver not yet moving           | "Why is it still 18 min? Is he stuck somewhere?"          | Worried    |
| Premature Call  | Calls the driver to verify         | Driver not in active window     | "I need to know if he's actually coming."                 | Stressed   |
| Cancellation    | Cancels. Opens Uber or Rapido.     | Platform loses the trip         | "This is too confusing. I'll use something I understand." | Frustrated |

#### USER PERSONAS

|                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                 |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                       |
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| <b>RK</b><br><b>Rohan K.</b><br><i>The Weekend Driver Outsourcer</i><br>"At that point, I don't want to guess what's happening. I just want to get home."<br><b>Context:</b> Late night, tired, possibly impaired. Low cognitive bandwidth.<br><b>Goal:</b> Safe return home. Immediate reassurance. No ambiguity.<br><b>Pain:</b> Misreads driver assignment as active movement. Panics when ETA doesn't move. | <b>AN</b><br><b>Ananya N.</b><br><i>The Planned Yet Flexible Professional</i><br>"If I've booked in advance, I just want to know when the driver will actually start moving."<br><b>Context:</b> Airport rides, events. Plans occasionally shift last minute.<br><b>Goal:</b> Predictability. Clarity. Ability to modify without a full cancel.<br><b>Pain:</b> Can't tell if the driver is reserved or already en route. This creates false urgency. |
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#### SWOT ANALYSIS

|                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                      |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                     |
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| <b>STRENGTHS</b> <ul style="list-style-type: none"><li>– Trusted, background-verified drivers</li><li>– Strong service differentiation from Uber/Ola</li><li>– Fast, frictionless booking flow</li></ul>                                             | <b>WEAKNESSES</b> <ul style="list-style-type: none"><li>– Post-assignment lifecycle is ambiguous and unexplained</li><li>– Dynamic ETA misleads users on scheduled rides</li><li>– Confusion forces cancellations that damage trust</li></ul>                       |
| <b>OPPORTUNITIES</b> <ul style="list-style-type: none"><li>– Clarify system state immediately after assignment</li><li>– Reduce confusion-driven cancellations at scale</li><li>– Build stronger late-night and scheduled ride positioning</li></ul> | <b>THREATS</b> <ul style="list-style-type: none"><li>– Uber and Rapido offer more predictable post-booking UX</li><li>– Trust erodes fastest in high-stakes, late-night contexts</li><li>– Cancellation penalties accelerate churn rather than prevent it</li></ul> |

#### VALIDATED P0 PROBLEM

**P0: VALIDATED THROUGH RESEARCH**

**Occasional Need Users misinterpret the driver assignment stage because the platform never explains what early assignment actually means. This confusion, not driver quality or service reliability, causes anxiety, premature calls, unnecessary cancellations, and retention decline.**

## PHASE 3

### SOLUTION DESIGN & PRIORITISATION

#### From validated problem to structured solution

Root cause first, then ideation, then convergence via RICE. The insight that guided the entire solution: this is a communication problem, not a features problem. The platform doesn't need new capabilities. It needs to explain the ones it already has.

#### ROOT CAUSE ANALYSIS: WHY-WHY FRAMEWORK

|                |                                                                                             |
|----------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>PROBLEM</b> | Users cancel rides after driver assignment                                                  |
| <b>WHY?</b>    | Users feel anxious about pickup timing. They don't know what's happening                    |
| <b>WHY?</b>    | Users misinterpret driver movement. They assume he's already heading toward them            |
| <b>WHY?</b>    | The interface shows a dynamic ETA with no distinction between scheduled and immediate rides |

Three root causes at the bottom of the chain:

|                                                          |                                                                            |                                                      |
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| No distinction between immediate and scheduled ride ETAs | No structured lifecycle visibility. Users don't know what stage they're in | No explanation of what happens next after assignment |
|----------------------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------|

**CONCLUSION** This is a lifecycle communication problem, not a marketplace, pricing, or driver availability problem. The fix is in how the platform talks to users, not in the underlying service.

#### HOW MIGHT WE QUESTIONS

|                                                                        |                                                                                    |
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| How might we reduce anxiety during the post-assignment waiting period? | How might we clearly differentiate a scheduled ETA from a live one?                |
| How might we make ride progression feel predictable at every stage?    | How might we prevent panic cancellations with proactive, well-timed communication? |

#### PRIORITISATION: RICE FRAMEWORK

| SOLUTION                           | REACH | IMPACT | CONFIDENCE | EFFORT | RICE SCORE |
|------------------------------------|-------|--------|------------|--------|------------|
| "What Happens Next" Info Card      | 3     | 2      | 3          | 1      | 18         |
| Context-Aware ETA Messaging        | 3     | 3      | 3          | 2      | 13.5       |
| Structured Ride Lifecycle Timeline | 3     | 3      | 2          | 2      | 9          |

**Why I treated these as one integrated module, not three separate features**

The Info Card scores highest on RICE because it's low effort. But it only patches one branch of the root cause tree. The ETA logic and the Timeline address the deeper structural issue, which is the mental model mismatch. Shipping any one of them in isolation would give partial relief. Together, they close the loop entirely.

#### CURRENT FLOW VS PROPOSED FLOW

| STAGE           | CURRENT EXPERIENCE                                                                                                                                       | PROPOSED EXPERIENCE                                                                                                                                                                                 |
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| Driver Assigned | Dynamic ETA appears ("Driver 18 min away") with no context on whether this is a scheduled or immediate ride. User assumes movement is already happening. | Fixed pickup time is shown. A reserved status badge reads: "Driver reserved for your 10:00 PM pickup." The live ETA only activates when the driver actually starts moving.                          |
| Waiting Period  | No lifecycle visibility. User has no idea what stage they're in. The emotional dip begins here: call, wait, or cancel?                                   | A structured timeline shows: Assigned → Scheduled → En Route → Arriving. The current stage is highlighted. Transitions are triggered automatically by backend ride state.                           |
| Post-Assignment | No explanation card. No next-step guidance. User is left to interpret the situation independently, and they get it wrong.                                | "What Happens Next" card appears immediately. It explains driver movement logic in plain language, and surfaces Modify / Contact Driver / Support based on what's actually available at this stage. |
| User Decision   | Calls driver → panics → cancels → opens Uber                                                                                                             | Reads reserved status → understands → waits → ride completes                                                                                                                                        |

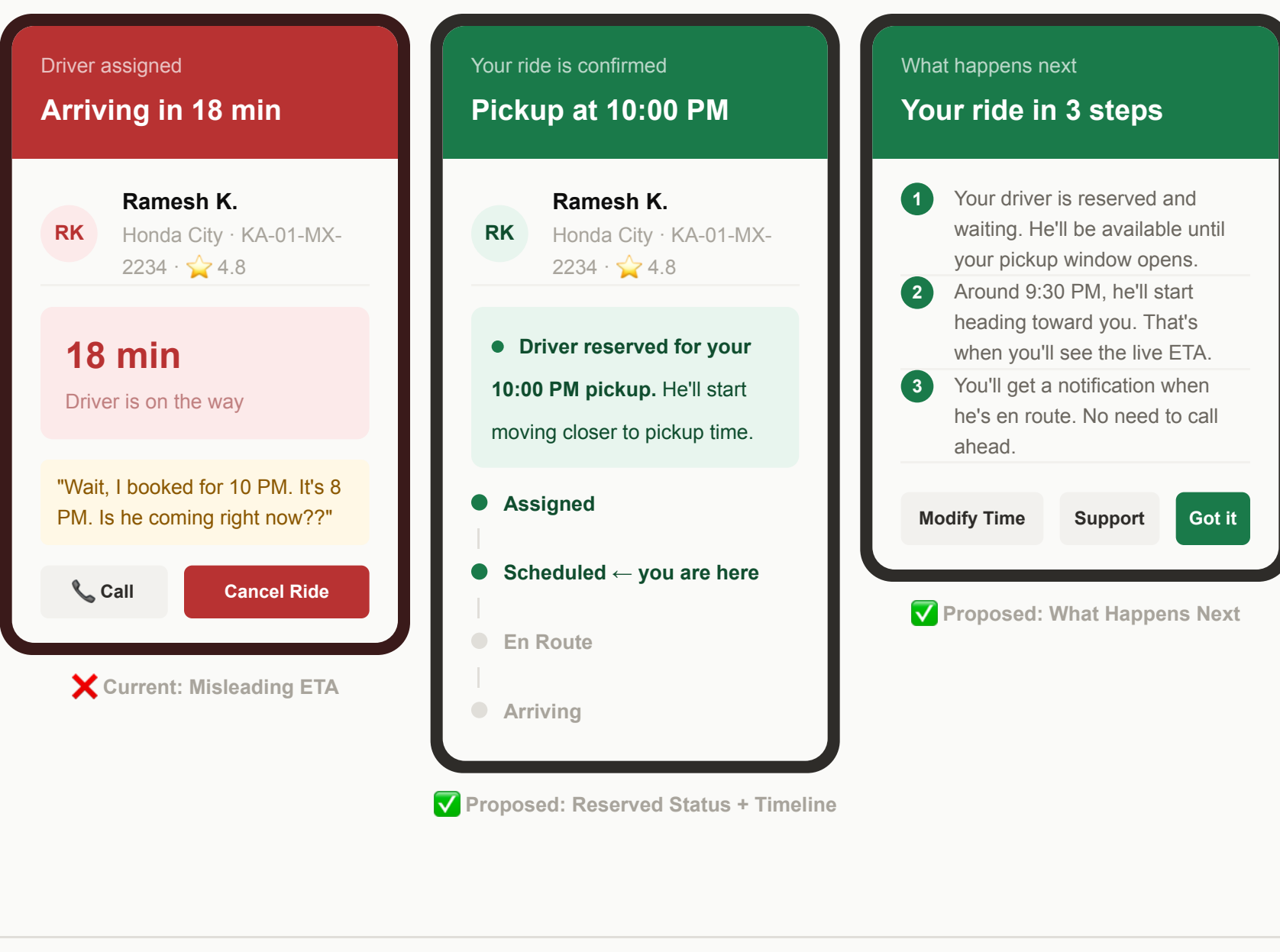
#### SOLUTION: POST-ASSIGNMENT CLARITY MODULE

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| <b>01 Driver Reserved Status Indicator</b><br>A visible badge that makes the system state explicit: "Driver reserved for your pickup at 10:00 PM. Movement begins closer to pickup time." This directly closes the mental model mismatch that drives confusion. The driver hasn't disappeared. He's committed, and the user now knows that.                    |
| <b>02 Context-Aware ETA Messaging</b><br>Immediate rides continue showing a live countdown ETA. Scheduled rides show the fixed pickup time instead. No more "Driver 18 min away" for a ride that's two hours out. The logic is driven by backend ride classification, so the right message always appears for the right ride type.                             |
| <b>03 Structured Ride Lifecycle Timeline</b><br>A simple visual progression: Assigned → Scheduled → En Route → Arriving. The current stage is highlighted; transitions fire automatically when backend ride state changes. For the first time, users have a shared vocabulary with the platform for what's happening to their ride.                            |
| <b>04 "What Happens Next" Information Card</b><br>Appears immediately after driver assignment. Explains in plain language: when the driver is reserved, when he'll start moving, and what the user should expect. Contextual actions surface only when they're operationally valid: Modify pickup time, Contact Driver, Support. No clutter, no false options. |

## PRODUCT SCREENS

#### Three screens that tell the story

The left screen shows what users see today and why it fails them. The two on the right show what the redesigned experience looks like: the Reserved Status screen and the What Happens Next card.



#### SUCCESS METRICS & RISK MITIGATION

##### Measuring the right outcomes

Success means a measurable drop in post-assignment cancellations, without creating new problems for drivers or operations. The guardrail metric is as important as the primary one: a solution that reduces rider cancellations by increasing driver idle time isn't a win.

|                                                                                                    |                                                                                                |                                                                                                                |                                                                              |
|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>PRIMARY METRIC</b><br><b>Cancellation Rate</b><br>Post-driver-assignment, Occasional Need Users | <b>SECONDARY METRIC</b><br><b>Premature Calls</b><br>Driver contact within 5 min of assignment | <b>SECONDARY METRIC</b><br><b>Modify/Cancel Ratio</b><br>Modification chosen as an alternative to cancellation | <b>GUARDRAIL</b><br><b>Driver Idle Time</b><br>Must not increase post-launch |
|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------|

#### RISKS & MITIGATION

|                                                                                                                                                                                                               |                                                                                                                                                                                                               |                                                                                                                                                                                                   |
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| <b>RISK 1</b><br><b>Users ignore the clarity messaging</b><br>Mitigation: Concise copy, strong visual hierarchy, with the key message in the first line. Detection: Cancellation rate unchanged post-release. | <b>RISK 2</b><br><b>Timeline misrepresents ride state</b><br>Mitigation: Tight backend-state synchronisation and QA validation across ride types. Detection: State mismatch logs or spike in support tickets. | <b>RISK 3</b><br><b>Modify option gets misused operationally</b><br>Mitigation: Restrict modification to a defined time window before pickup. Detection: Driver ride time increasing post-launch. |
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#### DEPENDENCIES

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|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Backend must formally classify rides as immediate or scheduled. This is the upstream dependency the entire solution rests on. | Ride lifecycle states must be formally defined and exposed to the frontend via API, with real-time transitions.                          |
| Frontend assignment screen requires a redesign to accommodate the new status badge, timeline, and info card components.       | QA validation across all ride types and edge cases, particularly around the scheduled-to-immediate state transition, before any release. |

**DESIGN PRINCIPLE**

The solution doesn't add new features to DriveU. It makes the ones that already exist legible. When users understand what the platform is doing, and why, they stop panicking. And when they stop panicking, they stop cancelling.